

creates a vacuum that makes the cup adhere to the baby's scalp. The doctor pulls downward while you push during a contraction.

Vacuum births are known to be very safe as long as you are at least 34 weeks pregnant. Before this time your baby's head may be too fragile to deal with the suction and few doctors use a vacuum before 32 weeks.

Pros and cons of vacuum This has some advantages over forceps; it is often a little easier to apply and may be less uncomfortable; it's less likely to cause vaginal and perineal damage and you'll be less likely to need an [episiotomy](#). There is a small risk of bruising of the scalp, but serious complications are rare; if your baby needs to be delivered, these small risks must be balanced against the risk of not delivering your baby.

Vacuum fails in up to 20 percent of cases, and it's especially likely to fail if the baby isn't in an ideal position or has a lot of hair or caput. If a vacuum comes off during the birth, it can be reapplied, or the doctor can reach for a pair of forceps instead. Sometimes, however, a cesarean has to be performed if the vacuum fails.

Pain relief

It can be painful having an assisted vaginal birth, so it is important that you have sufficient pain relief to help you cope with the delivery. In some situations, an injection of a local anesthetic in and around the vagina is sufficient to help you deal with the pain, particularly if the doctor is anticipating the birth to be fairly quick, and if your baby has already traveled most of the way through your pelvis. For more difficult assisted births, for example if the baby is not in an [occiput anterior position](#), an [epidural](#) may be given. This is especially useful if you're going to give birth in the operating room instead of the delivery room because forceps or vacuum have a high chance of failing, leading to the need for a cesarean. Finally, if you already have an epidural in place, this can be topped off with additional medication if needed.

METHODS OF ASSISTING BIRTH

Assisting your baby's birth with vacuum or forceps is a safe, well practiced procedure, which can prevent the need for an emergency cesarean. Whether you have forceps or vacuum may depend on the expertise and experience of the doctor carrying out the procedure.